School of the
ARTS AND ARCHITECTURE : World Arts and Cultures / Dance

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Selection Committee
Distinguished Teaching Award

February 2, 2026

Dear Selection Committee:

I write to nominate World Arts and Culture/Dance PhD student Wesleigh Gates (she/her) for a Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Gates is a fifth-year doctoral student in our program who is a thoughtful and highly accomplished educator as well as being a skilled researcher. It would be difficult to find a student instructor more capable and dedicated than Gates.

We have entrusted Gates with the opportunity to instruct our undergraduate students in our core courses, in both the Dance and World Arts and Culture majors. Gates has also served as a TA for two Writing II courses as well as a Masters of Social Sciences Program's writing TA. In addition, she acted as primary instructor for a WACD summer Writing II course, an opportunity offered to only a select few of our most capable graduate student employees.

Gates's teaching strengths hinge on her ability to identify and address barriers to student learning. Specifically, Gates focuses her teaching praxis on syllabus design as a means of creating equitable pedagogy and on the teaching of writing as a foundation for student success. Gates exhibits a great deal of initiative and generosity in the interest of enhancing access to learning. For instance, in a course that required writing assignments but offered no writing tutelage, she volunteered to lead workshops on her own time to promote student skill development. Gates similarly mentors undergraduate students in effective communication skills. She undertakes this additional labor to facilitate the access of first generation, non-traditional, and transfer students to the conventions of higher education.

Gates is dedicated to ongoing professional development. She has participated in the Writing Program's 495 courses and sought out an independent study to design an original syllabus as part of acting as the sole instructor for a summer session Writing II course. Moreover, Gates has demonstrated a commitment to undergraduate learning through participation in our department's advanced TA training course (WAC 496), an elective focused on syllabus design, as well as through participation in Teaching and Learning Center workshops.

In short, Gates is a skilled teaching practitioner who dedicates herself to continue improvement. Her commitment to pedagogical development is exceptional. Students speak highly of her skills and commitment, and faculty appreciate her dedication to teaching praxis. I submit this nomination enthusiastically and I hope you will look on it with favor.

Please feel free to contact me if you require further information: joshea@arts.ucla.edu

Best Regards,

Janet O'Shea
Professor and Chair
World Arts and Cultures/Dance

*The UCLA Department of World Arts and Cultures/Dance acknowledges the Gabrielino/Tongva peoples as the traditional land caretakers of Tovaangar (Los Angeles basin, So. Channel Islands) and is grateful to have the opportunity to work for the taraaxatom (indigenous peoples) in this place. As a land grant institution, we pay our respects to Honuukvetam (Ancestors), 'Ahiihirom (Elders), and 'eyoohiinkem (our relatives/relations) past, present and emerging.*

Wesleigh Gates
Dept. of World Arts and Cultures/Dance
DTA Self-Statement

I began training in evidence-based teaching during my masters' studies at Carnegie Mellon University, completing their teaching center's Future Faculty Program. Here at UCLA, I have deepened these pedagogical commitments, deploying and developing a variety of teaching practices that benefit the learning of a diverse student population. My instructional experience ranges from core courses for my department's two majors, to interdisciplinary courses in LGBTQ Studies and Disability Studies attracting students from across campus, to mentoring graduate students in the Masters of Social Science Program in thesis writing strategies.

As a TA, I prioritize supplementing lecture material to ensure students are as prepared as possible for assessments. As noted by my department chair, when assigned to TA a lower division course where all major assessments were written essays, I noticed that lectures did not include time for writing instruction and the course did not include a section (in which I might have focused on these skills), nor had many of these students completed Writing II. Prior to the first assessment, therefore, I held an optional group writing workshop for students wanting further clarification on writing expectations. I focused on breaking down complex writing prompts through the "They Say, I Say" approach to academic writing (Birkenstein, Graff, and Durst 2006), and clarifying primary elements of the assignment rubric such as developing an effective thesis statement and properly formatting citations. (See Artifact 2, Writing Workshop Slides.) I could see the successful implementation of this guidance in submitted work; students who attended the workshop averaged higher scores on the first written assessment than those who did not, and several students noted this additional support in their SET surveys (see Artifact 1, SET Comments).

In my classrooms, I place significant emphasis on cultivating engaged discussion. I always provide students the opportunity to collect their thoughts before sharing—whether through think/write-pair-share or requiring a discussion post before class—and begin conversations in small groups before moving to the full class. This gives students who may not feel comfortable speaking in the larger group an opportunity to share, and instills a sense of learning as a collective activity. The small-group approach was specifically noted in SET surveys by an ESL student as helpful for their learning. Given the importance of discussion to my pedagogy, I prioritize creating a classroom environment where students feel safe to participate and converse across backgrounds, viewpoints, and lived experiences. In the first week of classes I

ask students to brainstorm (in groups) discussion expectations for the course/section; these are brought to the full class for conversation, revision, and approval, becoming community agreements for the remainder of the term (see Artifact 3, Sample Community Agreements). Students have favorably highlighted my classroom discussion climate and facilitation in SET surveys.

My pedagogy invites students to perceive their lived experience as a resource for knowledge and understanding. In the course I am currently teaching as lead instructor (LGBTQS 183), this is an explicitly articulated learning objective, and assessments have been designed accordingly. Developing an approach to inquiry that is both personal and rigorous is a skill, meaning students need opportunities to practice. I scaffold this skill development via weekly discussion posts (see Artifact 4, Discussion Post Rubric) before the first major assessment, which focuses explicitly on this learning objective (see Artifact 5, Reflection Paper Assessment) in preparation for later, more complex assessments that ask students to use this approach to identify, motivate, and support independent research projects. My teaching statement details an example of how students have successfully mobilized this approach to advance their own research.

SET surveys affirm that I convey expectations clearly and thoroughly in syllabi, slides, assignment prompts, and classroom conversations; that I provide timely and implementable feedback on student work; and that students understand where and how to reach me for guidance outside of class, and feel encouraged and supported in doing so. In-class support has led numerous students to seek me out for mentorship beyond the duration of a given course. I have written recommendation letters for graduate school and for jobs, and have provided external opportunities that will enhance students' learning and fit their articulated values and/or career goals: one undergraduate student co-facilitated a campus teach-in (on contemporary LGBTQ issues) with me, and a student whose artistic practice I was mentoring took on a guiding collaborative role in a performance project I led at a local LA arts nonprofit. It is a privilege to champion my students in their efforts to engage with and transform their world(s).

Wesleigh Gates
Dept. of World Arts and Cultures/Dance
DTA Teaching Statement

As an educator committed to equitable and student-centered pedagogy, I understand the classroom as a site not for acquiring knowledge as a possession, but rather engaging learning as a practice. From the beginning of each course, I let students know (both verbally and in writing) that I prioritize their growth, their self-reflection, and their active participation in the classroom community above the notion of mastery. In courses where I am the primary instructor, I codify these priorities in course learning objectives, assessments, and grading rubrics. When assisting in courses where such metacognitive processes may not be explicit objectives, I work to help students situate required skills or content in this context of learning as a lifelong practice.

For instance, when teaching scholarly writing, I encourage students to understand clarity of structure and argument as a way of practicing accessibility—of ensuring their ideas can be clearly understood by a broad range of audiences. While a teaching assistant for the writing course *Perspectives on Disability Studies*, a student approached me to discuss their frustration with the writing rubric; they perceived its required structure as forcing them to oversimplify their argument and downplay the personal importance of their community advocacy work. Over the course of several in-class lessons and one-on-one conversations, this student arrived at a clear and well-supported articulation of how the community work they were doing intervened in and expanded the conceptual frameworks we'd discussed in class. Arriving at this articulation transformed not only their writing, but their sense of themselves and their activities as actively producing knowledge. Based on this experience, in subsequent writing classes I have incorporated an original exercise where I ask students to answer a series of questions in the drafting stage, including: *how is this argument important to you? Who would you ideally like to read or hear your paper? What goes unquestioned or unsaid if you don't say it?* Then, together, we discuss how required elements might facilitate these priorities. Such exercises encourage students to situate required skills in the context of their own values, facilitating the kind of self-reflection characteristic of engaged learners.

My pedagogy proceeds from the premise that both students and instructor are individual bodyminds who think, learn, and process differently, and that such difference is a benefit to collective learning. I emphasize to students that our backgrounds—including our location(s) along axes of race and ethnicity, gender and sexuality, class and ability—fundamentally shape us as embodied learners and thinkers. Accordingly, my class plans

and assessments offer explicit invitations for students to draw on and share lived experience via discussions and written reflections. (Such invitations are always accompanied by clarification that students determine what, how, and if they share; these are open-ended prompts to thought and connection, never mandates to disclose or extract.) I further highlight experience as resource through innovative instructional techniques that train students in creative methods of inquiry. For example, in a lesson on researching urban space in the course *Introduction to Field-Based Research Methods*, I asked students to draw maps of a commute they make regularly—to campus, to work, to family or friends or a favorite destination—and specifically to highlight borders, boundaries, and crossings. Discussing the resulting maps, students not only showed evident investment in sharing their lives with their peers and making connections with one another, but also demonstrated evolving understanding of relevant concepts (such as scale and mobility). Several students adapted and incorporated the mapping technique into their own final independent projects: designing mapping exercises based on their research questions, doing these exercises with interlocutors, and successfully incorporating the resulting data into final presentations. In other words, they learned not only to be rigorously curious about their own experiences and critically value them as knowledge, but to deploy this framework responsibly and effectively as researchers by making space for the experiences of others.

Guided by principles of accessibility, my course policies and lesson plans prioritize transparency and clarity while maintaining flexibility. Across courses, I provide rubrics for all graded elements (including participation expectations as well as major assessments), and maintain policies meant to provide space for a diversity of student needs while preserving student privacy. These include allowing several no-questions-asked absences (following recommended guidelines for trauma-informed teaching), as well as built-in check-in points before deadlines that give students an opportunity to reflect on their progress on the assignment and to request an extension if necessary. Such policies can ease the burden experienced by students who need support, such as those navigating disabilities, chronic illness, caregiving responsibilities, or difficult circumstances at home. I consider these measures part of the vital project of shifting an often grind-driven campus culture, especially in an era of compounding social, political, and ecological crises. I regularly engage my colleagues in conversation about how best to balance high expectations with flexibility that recognizes our ever-changing teaching and learning conditions (both individual and collective); several graduate student instructors in my own department and beyond have adopted or adapted my policies for their own syllabi.

Outside the classroom, I support students in cultivating soft skills that can be used in their broader educational journey and beyond. In my current department, I have

mentored undergraduate students (as well as fellow graduate students) in navigating unspoken "hidden curriculum" expectations, such as best practices for communicating with faculty and administrative staff. For example, several undergraduates approached me with the concern that our department lacked adequate facilities for them to work on the kinds of creative projects that their courses required. Through conversation and written feedback, I supported them in their attempts to gather peer support and approach department leadership with proposed solutions to the problem. The result of their advocacy was the transformation of an underutilized room into a collective creative workspace for undergraduate majors. As implicit localized norms of communication and procedure can be particularly opaque to international students or those who have taken non-traditional routes to higher education, such mentorship contributes to my overarching commitment to advancing equity and opportunity within the academy.

Wesleigh Gates

**Artifact 1: SET Survey Comments**

*General*

- Wesleigh is absolutely phenomenal. I want to be her student forever. I have no negative criticisms. Strengths: 1) Writing 2) communication 3) empathy 4) intention 5) feedback 6) knowledge of concepts 7) strives to connect with students *(WL ARTS 33, Winter 2023)*

*On Discussions and Classroom Climate*

- Wesleigh has been by far the best TA I have had as a WAC major. They made each student feel seen, heard, valued, and respected. Their approach to the course material was with compassion and sensitivity and it created a vulnerable but safe learning environment where every student's input was valued. I genuinely hope to take another course led by Wesleigh again in the future. *(WL ARTS 33, Winter 2023)*
- When I was unable to fully understand the material I would feel much more connected to the readings after discussions that allowed me to form my opinions and observations about the interconnectedness between my experiences and the content of the readings. *(DANCE 101, Spring 2023)*
- The encouraging and welcoming environment that Wesleigh created within the classroom encouraged me, a diagnosed socially anxious person, to actively participate. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2023)*
- Out of all the courses I have taken at UCLA, this classroom environment was the most comfortable I have ever felt to share in. The instructor made rules with students the first day, which were followed from everyone. They always made eye contact with students when they shared, and they gave a comment back rather than dismissing the comment and moving on to someone else. It made us (and me) feel heard. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2023)*
- The discussions in class were very welcoming and Wesleigh does a great job of forming questions that can be engaged with well. She also does a great job of responding to student comments and taking them even further in terms of engagement with material and connections to readings/other discussions/other comments made by peers. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2023)*
- The course included group and pair discussion. It was quite helpful since I could learn from others. Moreover, the explanation was so clear that I could understand what she taught us even though I am not a native English speaker. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*

- Always very welcoming and embraced our opinions to be shared no matter what, also ensured to create a safe environment for everyone in class that was set in place at the first day of class. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*
- I really appreciate the effort to know the names of each student, even those who don't speak up as much in class. It shows a lot of care! I also like that the class structure makes space for different types of participation (discussion post, small group discussion, journal prompts, etc.) *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*
- She constantly gave us opportunities to ask questions. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*
- Something that Wesleigh does that I really enjoy (and haven't encountered in any other class) was prompting people with "say more." I think it's an effective way to get clarification on what a student discusses as well as encourages literally saying more. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*

*On Clarity of Communication & Expectations*

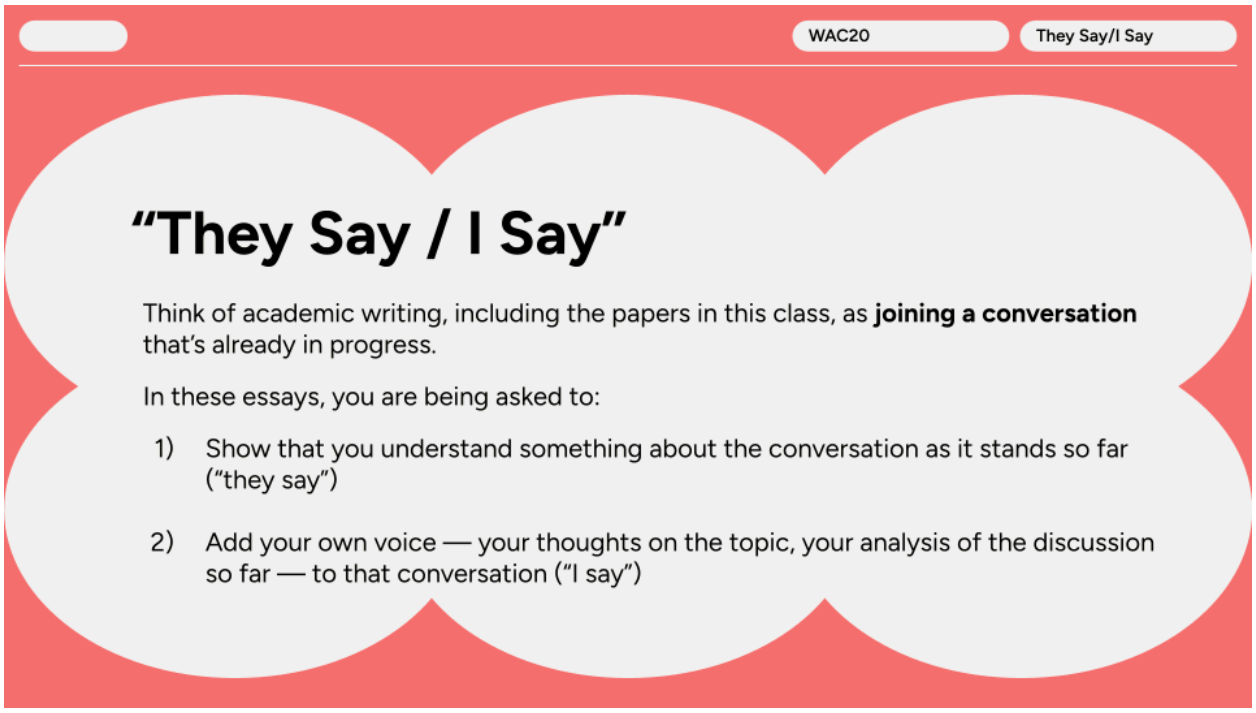
- She gave extensive feedback on student work which was refreshingly helpful in guiding students toward the larger assignments. *(DANCE 101, Spring 2023)*
- The syllabus for the class is really clear about what Wesleigh expects from students and their work. The slides are clear and concise, and the activities target what is expected of us and the skills we are trying to learn really well. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*
- Very organized structure in the class made it easy for me to know what I needed to do for this class and how to succeed in it. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*
- Wesleigh set up the class in a great way that allowed me to demonstrate my learning through submitting drafts and outlines which showed my progress when writing the essays. *(WL ARTS 51W, Summer 2024)*

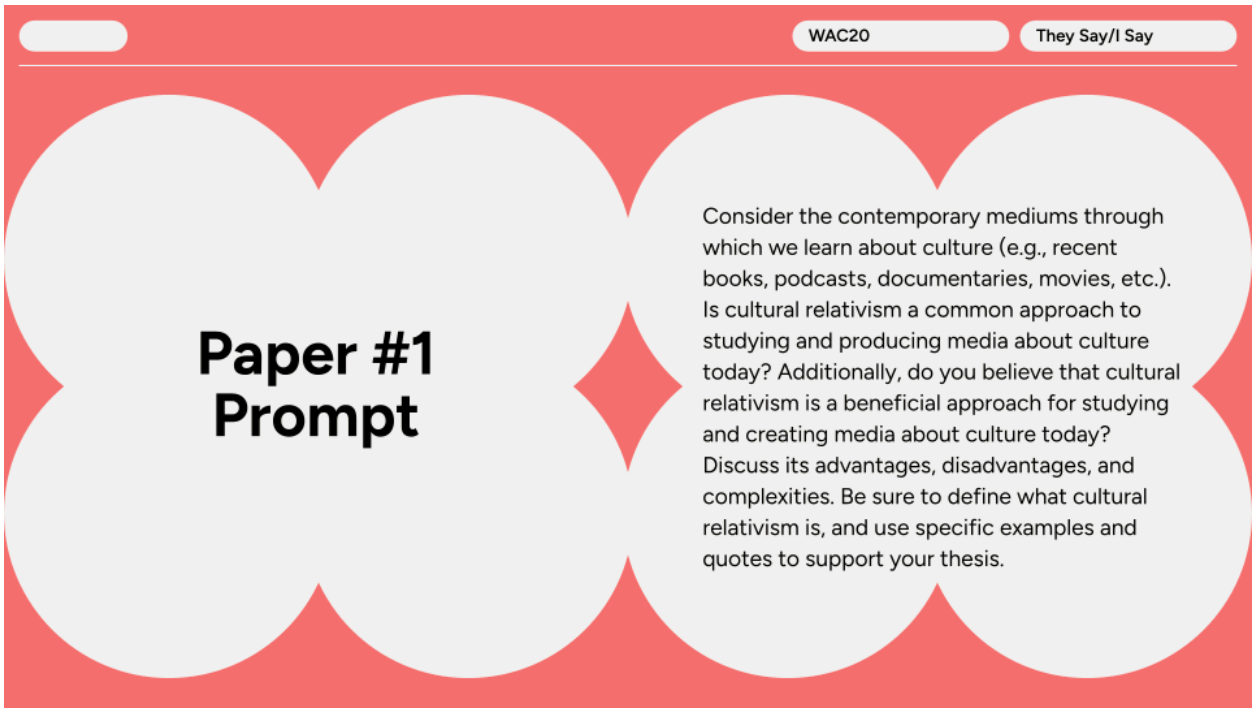
*On Providing Additional Support*

- Although we did not have a discussion section for this course, Wesleigh had available office hours to discuss any material related to the lecture discussions. They also provided a workshop at the beginning of the course to help students understand the expectations when it came to the writing style of the course as most of the graded materials were essays. During lectures, they provided examples of different topics if they became a little difficult to picture. *(WL ARTS 20, Winter 2025)*
- I really appreciated the additions to the discussions that they would add, just to make sure we were thinking more critically about what we were reading. They were always very approachable, and I appreciated her presentation on how to organize the writing assignments. *(WL ARTS 20, Winter 2025)*

Wesleigh Gates

**Artifact 2: Writing Workshop Slides**
**WL ARTS 20, Winter 2025 (T.A.)**



# Decoding Paper #1 Prompt

In your own words, what is this assignment asking you to do?

Can you identify which parts of the assignment prompt are asking you to analyze what "they say," and which are asking you to develop an "I say" in response?

## They Say

How have our readings defined cultural relativism, or offered examples that help us understand what it is?

What advantages/disadvantages have been discussed in the readings?

## I Say

Where do you weigh in on the existing discussion, including advantages/disadvantages?

Where can you find examples of the presence (or absence) of cultural relativism in contemporary media?

WAC20 They Say/I Say

# Practice

Copy and complete the following template based on one of our readings on cultural relativism:

**AUTHOR X, in their article _____, defines cultural relativism as _____.**
**One notable example they use to illustrate this definition is _____.**
**Their argument contributes to the larger conversation on this topic by highlighting _____.**

**One contemporary example that I believe relates to Author X's definition/argument is _____.**

**OR**

**While I agree with Author X regarding _____,**
**their article does not take into consideration _____.**

Wesleigh Gates

**Artifact 3: Classroom Community Agreements Developed With Students**
**LGBTQ Studies M114, Winter 2024 (T.A.)**

# COMMUNITY AGREEMENTS

- Practice open-minded engagement – respect, patience, listening, encouragement

- Speak from the "I"
    - Offer your perspectives from personal experience and try your best not to speak for other people
    - Recognize that everyone's perspective is informed by their experience and background, and this will be different for all of us

- Agree to disagree / challenge ideas, not people
    - If you hear something you don't agree with, you can challenge the idea or offer a different perspective without attacking the speaker

- Assume good INTENT, acknowledge IMPACT
    - If you hear something hurtful or disrespectful, bring it to the speaker's attention but do so with generosity
    - If someone lets you know they were hurt or upset by your comment, take responsibility and listen to learn what the concern was

- No question is a dumb question / we're all learning

- What's learned leaves, what's said stays
    - It's okay to talk about the content of our discussions outside class, but leave the details of who said what in the room

- Step up, Step Back
    - Be aware of your participation in discussion – make room for others to speak or challenge yourself to contribute

Wesleigh Gates

**Artifact 4: Discussion Post Rubric**
**LGBTQ Studies 183, Winter 2026 (Primary Instructor)**

RUBRIC FOR WEEKLY DISCUSSION POSTS
LGBTQS 183

| CRITERIA | FULL CREDIT | PARTIAL CREDIT | NO CREDIT |
|---|---|---|---|
| Engagement with assigned material | **2pts -** Post is concretely grounded in assigned material, with specific reference(s) including citation. | **1pt -** Post engages with assigned material but may do so in a general way rather than pointing to specific ideas, quotations, or moments. | **0pts -** Post does not engage with the day's assigned material. |
| Human being talking to other human beings | **2pts -** Post demonstrates a strong personal POV and a sincere effort to contribute to collective conversation. | **1pt -** Post may not show a clear personal POV, OR may not evidently be geared towards sparking collective conversation. | **0pts -** Post simply recaps or restates material without exploring personal response or considering how it might spark dialogue. |
| Effort & clarity | **1pt -** Post has been composed with care. | | **0pts -** Post appears sloppy, rushed, and/or unfinished. |

**TOTAL = 5pts**

Wesleigh Gates

**Artifact 5: Reflection Paper Assessment Prompt**
**LGBTQ Studies 183, Winter 2026 (Primary Instructor)**

In a personal essay of 4-5 pages (i.e. your work should be at least a few lines onto the fourth page, and not go over five), reflect on the ideas introduced in the course so far and how they sit alongside your previous understanding of the central course concepts *trans/body/horror*. Some questions to guide your writing (you do not have to answer every single one):

- What are the various ways our readings and class discussions have framed the relationship between embodiment and identity? How do these materials sit alongside your lived experience, or current popular discourse? Has your perspective shifted in any way since class began?
- How have you been trained to think about embodiment/bodies/"the body" in other classes, or in your major field? How do the ideas introduced so far sit alongside those other approaches?
- What do you understand, so far, as the particular stakes of discussions and theorizations of embodiment for trans and gender-variant people? Have these first few weeks changed anything about your thinking on this subject?
- How or why does horror make sense to you (or not!), so far, as a frame for thinking about embodiment and/or trans life? Do you have any personal relationship with the horror genre, and if so how has it shaped your approach to the course so far?

As these questions suggest, this is a personal reflection and first-person writing is not only encouraged but expected. At the same time, you are also expected to organize your ideas with care and to focus on engaging and synthesizing specific ideas from class. You should make substantial reference to **at least three of the required/suggested readings** (we will go over what "substantial" means in class); thorough responses will also engage ideas raised in class lectures/discussions. Outside references are welcome but not necessary. A bibliography/works cited is not required unless you do bring in outside references, however all references to readings in the essay should include correctly formatted in-text citations.

Your essay should be double spaced, written in 12pt Times New Roman font, and proofread for typos and clarity. The rubric for this assignment can be found here, and the citation expectations are here.

**Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation**

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

One of the things I've found most unique and intellectually challenging about the way Wesleigh Gates teaches is by encouraging students to interrelate the course material and their lived experiences. Through this, it has challenged me and my classmates to engage more critically with the course material and has allowed it to be more deeply situated and contextualized in current and historical events. Too often, my class materials, even when relevant to the current movement, have been taught in a way that has made it disattached from my life and community and those of my peers. Through challenging us to bring our own experiences and identities into the class with us, the material becomes more concrete and grounded. This has allowed me to take the concepts we have discussed in class into discussions or activities outside of an academic context. Through frequent small group and full class discussions, It has also given me the opportunity to learn from my classmates through engaging in a process of collective knowledge-building, rather than seeing the material merely as something to memorize or take in as fact.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

When I took LGBTQS 101, we learned about the history of organizing in the queer community in the US. After learning about these social movements, we did an activity where we planned an action or event. I enjoyed this activity, as I felt it made us go past the practice of simply taking in information, and actively challenged us to take inspiration from the material we had read in class to create something relevant to our own lives. This activity also particularly stuck with me as it was pretty unique in terms of assignments I've done at UCLA. It challenged us to step outside of our roles as academics, putting people outside of their comfort zones in a way that generated interesting conversations and reflections.

In the class I'm currently taking, I thought the framing of the reflection paper was also a good example of the practices I've described in the prior question. While in a traditional essay format, the framing of the paper was focused on the core themes of the class (embodiment, transness, horror), and asked us to reflect on our own relationships with and reactions to these topics, bringing ourselves into dialogue with the course materials.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

**Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation**

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

**Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation**

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name **Elaina Lorenzo Marino (she/they)**

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

**I first met Wesleigh when she was a T.A. in my Intro to LGBTQ Studies class in Fall 2024. We further connected when, during that quarter, we both attended the 2024 ASTR conference in Seattle. I then assisted her with a project through LA Performance Practice.**

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

**Wesleigh, through her teaching at UCLA and guidance beyond, inspires me to create art that is equal parts intellectually complex and personally relevant. Though I was not in her discussion section, she still worked closely with me during the LGBTQ Studies class to hone my final paper. She took the time to meet with me regularly and point me towards sources and readings that blended both her directing expertise and academia pursuits. When she knew someone with expertise in an interest of mine, she encouraged me to reach out to them; I felt my**

**network of collaborators blossom and my worldview widen. In late 2024, she invited me to be her Assistant Director for *The Grafters*, a work produced by LA Performance Practice. I helped her as she explored in real-time how to create a work with personal, material relevance to trans lives that also actualized the theories she taught in discussion. I was able to bring ways of theatermaking from this experience back to campus, where I began to integrate her methods of devising, collaboration, and directing to my school projects.**

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

**For her guest lectures, Wesleigh brought us incredibly specific frameworks and themes from her research and projects; these lessons illuminated the course's ideas while also expanding into areas the other materials did not delve into. Her acute, clear analysis of trans visibility opened the minds of both myself and my classmates. For this analysis, she blended personal anecdotes, artist perspectives (Juliana Huxtable), internet ephemera, and theory. Her teaching and discussion style is passionate, varied, and exciting. Even with the variety of forms brought in, the centering of all of it with a**

**deeply-researched framework (visibility) allowed it to remain clear and connected to our material lives, as well as our studies. Furthermore, she was an excellent and quick communicator outside of class, eager to help me and my classmates go deeper into our projects and interests. Our various office hour meetings were the reason I was able to not just improve my final essay, but take it to research events and co-found a Performance Studies group for other Undergraduate students. She helped us learn by always bringing the course's theories into our material lives, improving them immensely in the process.**

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

**Above all else, she is a collaborator, dedicated to collective learning and improvement above individual success. Her guest lectures took her direct teachings from her discussion sections to the entire class, answering students' questions and connecting her ideas with the professor's. This focus on group learning echoed in *Grafters* rehearsals, where the work evolved through discussions and ideas from the ensemble. It became an inspiring, varied, and cohesive portrait of divergent transfeminine**

**experiences, led the entire time by Wesleigh's focused direction. Overall, it is a privilege to know Wesleigh and carry her teachings forward through my life, art, and community.**

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February 5, 2026

Dear Selection Committee:

It is with pleasure that I write to recommend Wesleigh Gates for an distinguished teaching assistant award. Their research is one of the more rigorous that I have encountered. That said, to keep the word count to a minimum, I will speak here only about their teaching, which is beyond impressive to me.

Wesleigh TA'd for me five times, two of which were Writing II courses. She also took an independent study with me on pedagogy. Two of the TA positions were in the master's in social science (MASS) IDP, one course on thesis writing and one on theories of knowledge. I can speak to Wesleigh's teaching abilities perhaps better than any other graduate advisee in my life. And as my three previous teaching awards evidence, I am a devoted pedagogue. I care about teaching; and I am quite proud that Wesleigh is our department's nominee for the top teaching award available to graduate students. I could think of no one more suited for the honor.

Wesleigh has, since the first class with me in 2022, been one of those teaching assistants who goes beyond the expected role of "just doing the job." Wesleigh would come to my office and say that they noticed "a student struggling in the last assignment," or when a student's questions in the classroom was evidencing a misunderstanding of the reading. Wesleigh has always paid attention to the person in the seat, the human who could use a little extra help. Wesleigh would volunteer to teach exam study preparation sessions. They held their own "how to research" workshops. Wesleigh became the graduate student employee who I would ask to proofread my syllabi. We would talk about the pros and cons of possible readings or assignments. Perhaps I have spoken with Wesleigh about the craft of teaching than any of my faculty colleagues.

I have been impressed with Wesleigh in multiple areas of teaching, but perhaps none as much as their empathy toward students. Wesleigh helped students understand that struggling with writing is normal and expected, that reading dense theory should be challenging for most of us, that they (the students) were not abnormal or ill-prepared. In other words, Wesleigh's approach to teaching has been to affirm for students that they are where they belong. And frankly, that's sometimes just the traction a student needs to get through college. UCLA has been lucky to have Wesleigh in its classrooms.

Please do not hesitate to contact me if I can be of further assistance, particularly if there are questions about more stories of Wesleigh's approach to teaching.

Sincerely,



David Delgado Shorter
Professor
Director, Archive of Healing
Director, Wiki for Indigenous Languages

*The UCLA Department of World Arts and Cultures/Dance acknowledges the Tongva peoples as the traditional land caretakers of Tovaangar (Los Angeles basin, So. Channel Islands) and is grateful to have the opportunity to work for the taraaxatom (indigenous peoples) in this place. As a land grant institution, we pay our respects to Honuukvetam (Ancestors), 'Ahiihirom (Elders), and 'eyoohiinkem (our relatives/relations) past, present and emerging.*